

COMMITTEE
MEMBERS'
PAPERS
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Lodge System of
Masonic
Education
Utah, 1961

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THE LODGE SYSTEM OF MASONIC EDUCATION

Prepared by
GRAND LODGE COMMITTEE
on

MASONIC EDUCATION

Published by Authority of the
M.:W.:GRAND LODGE F. & A. M.
OF UTAH

Salt Lake City, Utah
December, 1961

The Interpretation of the Ritual of the Third Degree

Meeting No. 4

Subject No. 1

You have been raised to the Sublime Degree of Master Mason. It is indeed a “sublime” Degree which a man may study for years to come without exhausting it.

A hint may stimulate a man to reflect upon it for himself and to study it more

thoroughly in the future.

In the First and Second Degrees you were surrounded by the symbols and emblems of architecture; in the Third Degree you found a different order of symbolism, cast in the language of the soul-its life, its tragedy and its triumph. To recognize this is the first step in interpretation.

The second step is to recognize that the Third Degree has many meanings; it is not intended to be a lesson complete, finished, closed.

There are many interpretations of the Degree, all true. But most essentially it is a drama of the immortality of the soul, setting forth the truth that while a man withers away and perishes, there is that in him which perishes not.

That this is the meaning most generally accepted by the Craft is shown by our habits of language; we say that a man is initiated an Entered Apprentice, passed a Fellowcraft and raised a Master Mason; by this it appears that it is the raising that most Masons have found at the center of the Master Mason Degree.

What does this raising signify? If you have the answer to this question you can afterwards find your own way into all the meanings of the Degree.

The life of man is organized in a number of groups of experiences, each different from the others. Some experiences are incidental to our passage through time from childhood, through manhood, to old age. Some are incidental to the life of the body, hunger, sleep, weariness. Others cluster about the home and family; about religion, the meaning and purpose of life. Yet others have to do with a man's work, his trade or occupation. Some center about his life in the community as a neighbor or a citizen. Unless one be adequate to deal with all these groups of experiences, he cannot be happy.

The most difficult of all to deal with is that made up of the evils of life; hard experiences; sin, defeat, disease, loss of friends or fortune, enmity, treachery, sorrow, death. Herein lie our greatest problems, our severest testing. If we can find the wisdom to deal with these, if we can triumph over and solve their problems, our characters will be secure, our happiness assured. What you doing about evil in yourself and in the world about you? This is a question life asks each of us. If we fail of the right answer it enforces the worst of all penalties.

If evil come upon a man by his own acts, we feel that it is a just compensation; but what of the evil that comes upon a good man? Such we call tragedy, the supreme evil.

Evil in the form of tragedy is set forth in the Drama of the Third Degree. Here is a good and wise man, a builder, working for others and giving others work, the highest we know, as it is dedicated wholly to God. Through no fault of his own he experiences tragedy from friends and fellow Masons. Here is evil pure and unalloyed, a complete picture of human tragedy.

How did the Craft meet this tragedy? The first step was to impose the supreme penalty on those who had possessed the will to destruction and therefore had to be destroyed lest another tragedy fallow. The greatest enemy man has makes war upon the good; to it no quarter can be given.

The next step was to discipline and to pardon those who acted not out of an evil will, but out of weakness. Forgiveness is possible if a

man himself condemns the evil he has done, since in spite of his weakness he retains his faith in the good.

The next step was to recover from the wreckage caused by the tragedy whatever of value it had left undestroyed. Confusion had come upon the Craft; order was restored. Loyal Craftsmen took up the burdens dropped by traitors. It is in the nature of such tragedy that the good suffer for the evil, and it is one of the prime duties of life that a man shall toil to undo the harm wrought by sin and crime, else in time the world would be destroyed by the evils that are done in it.

But what of the victim of the tragedy? Here is the most profound and most difficult lesson of the Drama, difficult to understand, difficult to believe if one has not been truly initiated into the realities of the spiritual life. Because the victim was a good man, his goodness rooted in an unvarying faith in God, that which destroyed him in one sense could not destroy him in another. The spirit in him rose above the reach of evil; by virtue of it he was raised from a dead level to a living perpendicular.

Let us imagine a genuinely good man who has been the victim of the most terrible of tragedies, one caused by the treachery of friends. This treachery has brought destruction upon the foundations of his life, his home, his reputation, his ability to earn a livelihood. How can he be raised above the clutch of such circumstances? How can he emerge a happier man than before? By his spirit rising to the plane of forgiveness, refusing to stoop to retaliation or to harbor bitterness. In such a spirit the truest happiness is found.

The secret of such a power is in the Third Degree, symbolized by the Word. If that Word is lost, a man must search for it; if a man possesses that Word, he has the secret of the Masonic Art. To rise to the height of spiritual life is to stand on a level above the reach of tragedy or the powers of evil. To have the spirit rest in God, to have a sincere and unvarying faith in truth and goodness, is the inner secret of a Master Mason, to teach which is the purpose of the Third Degree.

Symbols, Emblems, and Allegories of the Third Degree

Meeting No. 4.

Subject No. 2.

In your experience with the Ritual you have learned that every detail in the ceremonies of initiation is full of meaning. In the Third Degree are the deepest secrets and the most profound teachings of our Fraternity. You passed through the Degree in one night: to understand it will require many nights. In these few minutes we can give you a few hints, in the hope that they may inspire you to study the Degree for yourself.

The symbolism of the First and Second Degrees centers around the art of architecture; their purpose is to teach you, in the First, to be a builder of yourself, in the Second, a builder of society. In the Third Degree the symbolism takes another form. Although its background continues to be architecture, and its action takes place in and about a Temple, it is a spiritual symbolism of life and death. Its principal teaching is of immortality.

If a man permit himself to be buried under the rubbish of sins and passions, it is possible, if he has learned the secret of the spiritual life and with the help of God and of the Brotherhood, to rise again into a new life. This gives us the key to the Degree, and in its light, all its symbols, emblems, allegories must be understood.

This note is struck in the Scripture Reading from the Book of Ecclesiastes, which pictures a man once flushed with health and strength, brought tottering by old age to the brink of the grave. This Chapter tells us, will become a light burden to him who has learned to trust God. God is the God of old age and of the soul after death as much as of youth and strength.

The Working Tools of the Degree are all the implements of Masonry, but more especially the Trowel by which we spread the cement of Brotherly Love. But Brotherly Love itself has its source and

seat in the soul. To love a man above his sins, to cherish him in spite of his faults, to forgive him in all sincerity, is possible only as we live in the spiritual life, our souls purged of selfishness.

The Tragedy of Hiram Abif is the climax of the Degree; is indeed the climax of all the ceremonies of Freemasonry. Next in importance is the allegorical Search for That Which Was Lost. This has a historical background. To the early Jewish people, the name of God was held in extreme reverence. This Holy name was never pronounced above a whisper; after a while only the priests were permitted to use it; finally only the High Priest, and then only when alone in the Holy of Holies on the Day of Atonement. During some national calamity, perhaps at the time of the Babylonian Captivity, the High Priest was destroyed before he had opportunity to pass it on to his successor. In that way the Name was lost.

The Name might have been preserved in the sacred writings of the Jews except that in their written language the vowels were understood, not written. The consonants of the Divine Name are known, J H V H, but not the vowels and therefore not the name.

All this appears in our Ritual in the form of an allegory. A Word was possessed; the Word was lost.

Like all symbols this means many things. One of its profounder meanings is that if a man has lost the ideals of his youth, his character, his faith in truth and goodness, the secret of what it is to be a man, he must, if he is to live the Masonic Life, go in search of that which was lost and continue searching until he finds it. Without manhood it is useless to be a man.

You may wonder why the Ritual does not explain fully the meaning of this symbolism, why it leaves the candidate to find the meanings for himself. There are three reasons for this silence. First, lack of time. To explain them all fully would require not three nights but perhaps three hundred.

Second, the Masonic life grows by what we do for ourselves, infinitely more than what others do for us. The Ritual presupposes

that we are grown men, not boys in school, and that each of us does his own thinking. Third, the method of the Ritual is to bring us into the presence of the greater truths of life knowing that their mere presence will have a deep influence over us; each man is left to work them out in detail according to his own needs.

Of the Emblems of the Third Degree one after another is set before us, apparently in no given order, and each with only a hint of what it signifies. Yet each of them stands for some great idea or ideal, necessary throughout our lives; and the purpose is to plant them in our consciousness, to keep them always in our presence.

Each of them is a master of truth. In the Three pillars we have the three great ideas of wisdom, of strength or power, of beauty.

The three steps remind us that Youth, Manhood and Old Age is each a unity in itself each possessing its own duties and problems, each calling for its own philosophy. The Pot of Incense teaches that, to be pure and blameless in our inner lives is more acceptable to God than anything else.

What a man really is, is of vastly more importance than that which he appears to be. The Book of Constitutions is the emblem of Law and that our moral and spiritual character is grounded in law and order as much as in government or nature. It teaches that no man can live a satisfactory life who lives lawlessly. The Sword Pointed to the Naked Heart discovers that one of the most rigorous of these laws is justice, and that if a man be unjust in his heart, the inevitable results of injustice will find him out. The All-Seeing Eye shows that we live and move and have our being in God; that we are constantly in His Presence, wherever or whatever doing.

The Anchor and the Ark stand for that sense of security and stability of life grounded in truth and faith. The Forty-Seventh Problem is an emblem of the Arts and Sciences; by them we are reminded that next to sinfulness the most dangerous enemy of life is ignorance. In the Hourglass we have the emblem of the transitoriness of life; no man lives forever in this world. The Scythe reminds us that

passing time will bring an end to our lives as well as to our work, and if ever we are to become what we ought to be, we must not delay.

Unhappy the man who reaches middle years having missed these undeniable and all-important truths. He has gone backward, not forward and is not blameless in his heart. Yet there is hope for him. The central teaching of the Master Mason Degree, expressed in the Tragedy of Hiram Abif, is a way for him to recover possession of his life. He can be raised to a new manhood lifted from the dead level of death to a living perpendicular. He may be called back from a grave that is more terrible than the dissolution of the body. By repudiation and death of his old life, by gaining again his faith in God by the Power of Brotherhood, he finds the path to recovery.

The Legend of Hiram Abif

Meeting No. 4.

Subject No. 3.

In the Sublime Degree you were impressed by the Tragedy of Hiram Abif above all other features of its impressive ceremonies. As the Degree is the climax of initiation so is the Tragedy the climax of the Degree. To understand its meaning will be a prized possession as long as you live.

Drama is a conflict between a man and other men, or other forces, resulting in a crisis in which his life or fortune is at stake. The crisis, or problem, is followed by a resolution or solution; if it favors the man the drama is a comedy, in the original meaning of that word. If it turns against him, and he becomes a victim or a sufferer, the drama is tragedy. Plays acted on the stage are not dramas but representations of dramas. The Masonic Drama is of that which occurs in our own lives, to each of us in our daily experience.

The Tragedy of Hiram Abif is a ritualistic drama. Ritual is the set words and fixed ceremonies addressed to the human spirit through imagination. A play in the theatre may be built around some historical figure or event! as in Shakespeare's plays about the English Kings. If the figures and events are not actually historical, they are supposed to be, so that time, place and identity are of importance. A ritualistic drama moves wholly in the realm of the spirit, where time, space and particular individuals are ignored. The clash of forces, the crises and fates of the human spirit alone enter into it, and they hold true of all men everywhere.

Since the Drama of Hiram Abif is ritualistic, it is a mistake to accept it as history. There was a Hiram Abif in history, but our Third Degree goes far beyond what history tells of him. Our Hiram Abif is a symbol of the human soul. If, therefore, you have been troubled with the thought that some of the events of this drama could not have happened, you can ease your mind. If they never happened in history, they are symbols of what happens in the life of every man.

It is an inexcusable blunder to treat the drama as a mock tragedy, a serio-comedy. Savage peoples employ initiation ceremonies as an ordeal, but Freemasonry is not savage. Boys in school enjoy hazing but Freemasonry is not juvenile. The exemplification of our ritualistic drama should be as sincere, as solemn, as earnest as a prayer before the Altar; he who takes it trivially or with perverted humor, betrays a shallowness of soul which shows him unfit to be a Mason.

Hiram Abif is a symbol of the human soul. The work he was engaged to supervise is the symbol of the work we do, when we supervise, organize and direct our lives from birth to death. The enemies he met are symbols of those lusts and passions which in our breasts make war on our characters. His doom befalls every man who becomes a victim to those enemies; to be interrupted in his work, to be made outcast from the mastership over himself and, at the end, to be buried under all manner of rubbish, ill fame, defeat, demoralization, disgrace, weakness, misery, evil habits and scorn.

The manner in which he was raised from a dead level to a living perpendicular is the way by which any man rises from self-defeat to self-mastery. And the Great Architect, by the power of whose word Hiram Abif was raised, is the God in whose arms we ourselves forever lie, and whose mighty help we also need to raise us out of the grave of defeat.

Did you ask, while participating in that drama, why you were made to participate; why you were not permitted to sit as a spectator? It was YOUR drama not another's. No man can ever be a mere spectator of drama in his own soul. It was intended that your participation would prepare you for becoming a Master Mason by teaching you the secret of a Master Mason, by which the soul may rise above its internal enemies if a man is a Mason in reality as well as in name. The real Master Mason is master of himself.

Did you ask why the three enemies came from his own circle, not from the outside? The enemies most feared by the soul are always from within: its own ignorance, lust, passions, and sins. As the Great

Light reminds us, it is not that which kills the body that we need most to shun, but that which has power to destroy the spirit. Did you ask why it was that there was so much confusion among the Craftsmen? The temple is the symbol of a man's character, and therefore breaks and falls when the soul, its architect, is helpless.

The most we can obtain from others is such hints and suggestions as these. Print the story of Hiram Abif indelibly upon your mind: ponder it. When you are at grip with your enemies, recall it and act according to the light you find in it. Your inner self will give, in the form of first-hand experience, that which the drama gave in the form of Ritual, and you will be wiser and stronger for having the guidance and the light the Tragedy provides.

The Duties, Privileges, and Rights of a Master Mason

Meeting No. 4

Subject No. 4.

You will not find the duties, rights and privileges of a Master Mason anywhere clearly stated and numbered. They are scattered here and there; some are explicit, others are implied.

A Master Mason's first duty is obviously to live by and act consistently with his obligation. With this as a foundation, a number of those duties and rights can be discussed.

It is a Master Mason's duty to pay his share of the financial costs of the Fraternity, promptly and ungrudgingly. If he be unaffiliated, he has the right to petition for membership in some Lodge. He may choose the Lodge to which he makes his petition, but he should seek membership in some Lodge.

A Master Mason has the right to ask for a demit or a certificate of good standing and if he be clear of the books and no charges have been- or are about to be preferred against him the Lodge must grant it. One may hold his membership where he is happiest or it is most convenient, provided he is elected to membership in that Lodge.

Visiting in Lodges in which he does not hold membership is both a right and a privilege, though not a duty. It is a right in the sense that he may seek admittance into any regular Lodge; it is a privilege in the sense that his admission into that Lodge is contingent upon his being vouched for and being examined and being permitted to enter by the Worshipful Master.

If he seeks to visit a Lodge, he has the privilege of being vouched for if some member of it has sat in Lodge with him so that he is not compelled to undergo examination every time he seeks to visit. Masonic relief, like visiting, is both a right and a privilege. Every Mason has the lawful right to ask for it upon need, without derogation

to his dignity or endangering his standing. It is a privilege in that neither a Lodge nor a Master Mason is compelled to give relief. The Lodge is not an insurance society, an organized charity, or a death benefit association, nor is any guaranty given any member that he will receive what he asks. Each Lodge and each Mason is under obligation to heed the call for relief, but each is free to use judgment whether or not to extend relief.

If he be brought to trial in his own Lodge on charges of un-Masonic conduct and found guilty, he has the right of appeal to the Grand Lodge. This right is his guaranty against possible injustice or spiteful prosecution by some private enemy.

Every Master Mason has the right of Masonic burial (unless of course, the conduct of the deceased in his later years has reflected discredit upon the Fraternity).

Among the most important of his rights, though exercised under unhappy conditions, is his right of trial by his peers, under regulated conditions, with freedom to present evidence. This assures him that no Lodge can degrade him without a fair trial. Neither his Lodge nor any officer or member can remove him through malice or spite; nor can he be made to suffer the penalties of Masonry out of idle gossip or hearsay. Right of trial guarantees him all the securities of justice.

A Mason's privileges are to be described in principle and in spirit rather than in detail because they vary much and depend on local conditions. He has the right of a voice in his Lodge, a vote, and to hold office. He has also the privilege of giving Masonic service, one of the principal sources of the joy in Masonic life. A Lodge may do many things which are neither required nor prohibited by law; it may hold social affairs, give special entertainments, foster some Masonic educational enterprise, may have a library- all according to the wishes of its members. The Grand Lodge offers many privileges which are as open to the individual Mason as to the Lodge. Membership gives no man the right to demand things of either the Lodge or the Grand Lodge, but if they are offered, every member has the right to enjoy them.

Beyond all these specific duties, rights and privileges stands a more general region in which all are mingled together; the whole domain of Masonry's teachings, her Ritual and symbols, her history, her ideals of jurisprudence, her philosophy, her literature, the whole Royal Art. It is the right of a Master Mason to be taught that Art and to have it in its fullness. Freemasonry in all her height, and breadth and length and richness belongs to you to use and enjoy.

The Grand Lodge Library and the Literature of Masonry

Meeting No. 4

Subject No. 5.

It has been said upon good authority that more books have been written about Freemasonry than upon any other single subject. The fact to be remembered is that we possess an extraordinarily rich literature about the Fraternity in all its branches and aspects, and any Brother who wishes to enjoy his Masonry to the full will necessarily make use of it.

Our literature divides itself naturally into a series of divisions:

HISTORY. Our written records cover some six centuries of time, but at the time

the first of these documents was written, which was about 1390 A. D., the Craft already was old; it had in its beginning inherited much from secret fraternities that had gone before; therefore our historians must go much farther back than 1390. At the same time, they must range far afield, and they must often deal with fraternities with which Freemasonry is, or has been historically connected. Speaking in the large, Masonic History breaks into the following subdivisions: general history, history country by country, history Grand Lodge by Grand Lodge, and Lodge history. In the same general field would fall biographies, histories of buildings, and histories of single objects Auch as Ancient Manuscripts, etc.

RITUAL AND SYMBOLISM. A writer on this subject might try to trace the origin of some element in the Ritual; or he might try to explain a symbol or ceremony; or interpret its meaning. A great mass of material exists on the Ritual in many languages and from every conceivable point of view of Masonic thought.

PHILOSOPHY. This deals with the teachings of Masonry, what Masonry stands for, what its ideals are, what it is trying to do. The

term “Masonic Philosophy” may be justly defined in either of two ways; it may mean an effort to study Masonry itself by philosophical methods as philosophers study other subjects; or it may mean Masonry's own philosophy of life.

JURISPRUDENCE. Masonic law exists in two main branches, Unwritten Law and Written Law. By Unwritten Law is not meant that it is never written down. Under this head fall the Ancient Landmarks, Old Charges, Ancient Constitutions, traditions, customs and usages. By the Written Law are meant Grand Lodge Constitutions, Codes, Statutes, Rules, Definitions, Regulations and Edicts, and Lodge By-Laws.

REFERENCE. By this is meant such books as dictionaries etc. Grand Lodge Proceedings, handbooks.

GENERAL LITERATURE. Under this is included fiction, poetry, drama, humor, music and all other such books as do not fall easily under the heads already given.

Doubtless you are asking in your mind how you may secure the use of this literature. Fortunately for us in this Jurisdiction a remarkably convenient and efficient means has been provided for us. In addition to the libraries of our respective Lodges, Grand Lodge maintains a Masonic Library at the Masonic Temple in Salt Lake City, which it places at the disposal of every Master Mason on our rolls. This includes you.

You may borrow books from the Grand Lodge Library in the same manner as from a public library or from your Lodge library. All you have to do is to register as a borrower giving the name and number of your Lodge. If a Mason lives near enough to visit it in person he may borrow books for a period of two weeks subject to renewal for two weeks; if not, he may borrow by mail, keeping them for two weeks subject to renewal for two weeks, the Library paying postage one way.

The Grand Secretary is ex-officio Grand Librarian. His office is in the Masonic Temple, Salt Lake City, adjoining the library. He, or any

member of the Grand Lodge Committee on Masonic Education, will assist any Brother in obtaining information about the library, its books and records.

You are urged to make use of this opportunity to find more light in Masonry and, while it is not in the province of this committee to lay out a recommended course of reading, least of all to suggest a list of titles, you are most earnestly counseled to read at least one modern, well-written book on each of the principal subjects; history, symbolism, ritual, philosophy, and juris prudence.

You have now entered that country called Freemasonry. It spreads out from your feet farther than your eyes can reach, through time and space. It belongs to you. Literature exists to help you put yourself in possession of it.

